

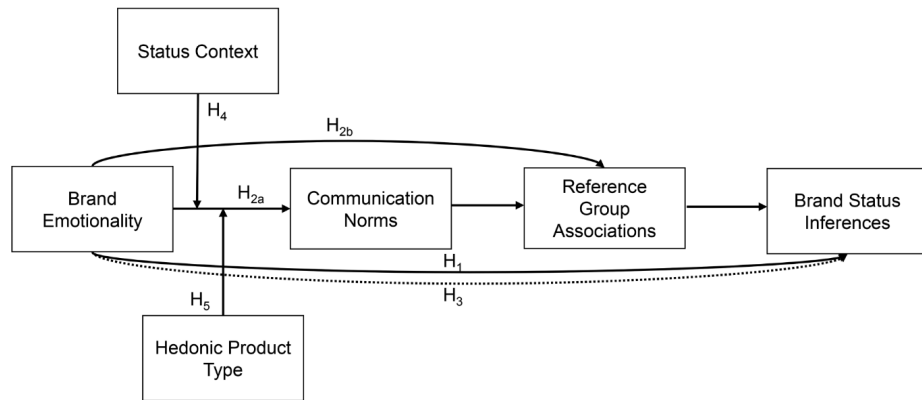
## Response Letter with Annotations

Lee, J. K. (2021). Emotional Expressions and Brand Status. *Journal of Marketing Research*, 58(6), 1178–1196. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00222437211037340>

### Annotations

#### 1. Purposes

- a. Motivation (one-sentence summary): This article aims to investigate how brand emotionality in social media posts shape brand perceptions regarding brand status.
- b. Specific Rationale (several bullet points)
  - a. Emotionality becomes increasingly important for content virality.
  - b. However, the potential negative effects of higher levels of emotionality for marketing remains underexplored.
  - c. Theoretically, canonical cultural theory, positing that lowered emotional expression is associated with high status, has not been proven through large dataset.
- c. Research Questions and/or Hypotheses
  - a. **H1:** Brands that engage in lower emotionality generate inferences of higher brand status.
  - b. **H2:** Brands that engage in lower emotionality (a) increase perceptions of alignment with high-status communication norms and (b) evoke higher-status reference groups.
  - c. **H3:** The negative relationship between brand emotionality and perceived brand status is mediated by alignment with high-status communication norms, which evokes associations with higher-status reference groups.
  - d. **H4:** The negative relationship between brand emotionality and perceived brand status is greater in higher- (relative to lower-) status contexts.
  - e. **H5:** The negative relationship between brand emotionality and perceived brand status is reduced when brands communicate about hedonic products
- f. Identify IV, DV, mediator, moderator
  1. **IV:** Brand Emotionality
  2. **DV:** Brand Status Inference
  3. **Mediators:** (1) Communication Norms, (2) Reference Group Associations
  4. **Moderators:** (1) Status Context, (2) Hedonic Product Type
- g. Identify specific relationships among variables



## 2. Method

### Study 1a

- a. Research Design: Content analysis
  - a. Data source: field data in the form of social media posts by brands on Twitter
  - b. Breakdown steps: (1) generate a list of brands to analyze their communication goals on social media; (2) preprocess all text data; (3) assess emotionality in the text data by measures from previous marketing research, Evaluative Lexicon and LIWC; (4) analyze the relationship between the measures of emotionality and brand status by ordinary least squares exercise.
- b. Sample (representative sample?)
  - a. Over 160,000 tweets from 74 brands in the luxury personal goods market
- c. Measures: emotionality in the text data by several Python packages
- d. Analysis: statistical analysis conducted by ordinary least squares exercise

### Study 1b

- a. Research Design
  - a. Content analysis: the images included in the tweets collected in Study 1a
- b. Sample
  - i. Approximately 91,148 images posted by 74 brands
- c. Measures: Face API's summed "emotionality score" to capture ratings on emotions including anger, contempt, disgust, fear, happiness, sadness, and surprise.
- d. Analysis: (1) Use Face API to analyze the emotionality of faces; (2) Explored the interplay of image and text emotionality on brand status by regressions

### Study 1c

- a. Research Design
  - b. Content analysis: social media posts on Weibo of the same list of brands in Study 1, from January 2018 to September 2019
- b. Sample: 29,831 images with faces

- c. Measures: Same as Study 1b, Azure's Face API to quantify emotionality from facial expressions
- d. Analysis: Follow the same steps as Study 1b

## **Study 2**

- a. Research Design (Experiment)
  - c. Conditions: 3 (Status Context)  $\times$  2 (Brand Emotionality) between-subjects experiment
  - d. Manipulations:
    - 1. Perceived Brand Status manipulated by different cuisine types:
      - a. French cuisine – high status,
      - b. Mexican cuisine – medium status,
      - c. American cafeteria food – low status
    - 2. Brand Emotionality manipulated by textual paralanguage:
      - a. All sentences ended in a period – low brand emotionality
      - b. All sentences ended in an exclamation point – high brand emotionality
- b. Sample
  - i. 629 North American residents, recruited from Amazon Mechanical Turk (MTurk) (Average age = 37 years; 307 women)
- c. Measures
  - i. Brand status (4 items): high-status, well-respected, prestigious, high-end
  - ii. High-status reference group associations (3 items): for rich people, very expensive, elitist
  - iii. Manipulation check: Emotionality scale
- d. Analysis
  - i. A 3 (status context: low, moderate, high)  $\times$  2 (brand emotionality: lower vs. higher) between-subjects ANOVA.
  - ii. To test mediation and moderated mediation, the authors used PROCESS Model 8 (Hayes, 2017) with bootstrapped confidence intervals.

## **Study 3**

- a. Research Design (Experiment)
  - e. Conditions: Brand Emotionality (low vs. moderate vs. high) between-subjects experiment
  - f. Manipulations
    - 1. Low emotionality – sentences ended with a period
    - 2. Medium emotionality – sentences ended with one exclamation point
    - 3. High emotionality – sentences ended with three exclamation points and capitalization of a word or phrase
  - g. Stimuli: Tweets adapted from real fashion brands
- b. Sample: 425 North American residents, recruited from Amazon Mechanical Turk (MTurk), average age = 41 years, 206 women
- c. Measures
  - i. Brand status (same scale as Study 2)

- ii. High-status reference group associations (3 items): For rich people, very expensive, elitist
  - iii. Norm alignment (single measure): “To what extent does this language conform to a high-end fashion brand’s communication style?”
- d. Analysis
  - i. One-way ANOVA examining the effect of brand emotionality (low vs. moderate vs. high) on: Brand status, Norm alignment, High-status reference group associations
  - ii. Mediation analysis: PORCESS 6 with bootstrapped confidence intervals

#### **Study 4**

- a. Research Design (Experiment)
  - i. Conditions: 2 (Product Type: hedonic vs. nonhedonic)  $\times$  2 (Brand Emotionality: lower vs. higher) between-subjects experiment
  - ii. Manipulation
    - 1. Product type manipulated via car model:
      - a. Convertible – hedonic product
      - b. Sedan – nonhedonic product
    - 2. Brand emotionality manipulated via:
      - a. Textual paralanguage (e.g., exclamation points)
      - b. Emotionally intense vs. emotionally neutral evaluative words
      - c. Visual emotional expression in images
- b. Sample: 223 North American residents recruited from MTurk (Average age = 42 years; 114 women)
- c. Measures:
  - i. Brand status (same scale as Studies 2–3)
  - ii. High-status reference group associations
  - iii. Norm alignment with high-status communication (4 items,  $\alpha = .959$ )
  - iv. Manipulation check: Emotionality scale
- d. Analysis:
  - i. Moderated mediation analysis using PROCESS Model 85 (Hayes, 2017) with bootstrapped confidence intervals

### **3. Results and Conclusions**

#### **Study 1a**

- a. Answers to RQs and Hypotheses: H1 was supported for textual data: a negative relationship between brand emotionality and brand status for textual data
- b. Include Key Figures/Tables

**Table 2.** Relationship Between Emotionality and Median Price (Study 1a).

| DV = Median Price        | Emotionality IVs   |      |                               |      |                            |      |                                     |      |                             |      |                                 |      |
|--------------------------|--------------------|------|-------------------------------|------|----------------------------|------|-------------------------------------|------|-----------------------------|------|---------------------------------|------|
|                          | Exclamation Points |      | Normalized Exclamation Points |      | Presence of Capitalization |      | Whissell's Activation Subdictionary |      | LIWC's Affect Subdictionary |      | Evaluative Lexicon Emotionality |      |
|                          | B                  | SE   | B                             | SE   | B                          | SE   | B                                   | SE   | B                           | SE   | B                               | SE   |
| <b>Predictors</b>        |                    |      |                               |      |                            |      |                                     |      |                             |      |                                 |      |
| Emotionality IV          | -.246**            | .067 | -.383***                      | .074 | -.158                      | .128 | -.100**                             | .047 | -.010***                    | .003 | -.027*                          | .016 |
| <b>Control Variables</b> |                    |      |                               |      |                            |      |                                     |      |                             |      |                                 |      |
| Word count               | .018***            | .005 | .019***                       | .005 | .018***                    | .005 | .017***                             | .005 | .015***                     | .005 | .013**                          | .006 |
| URL                      | .020               | .051 | .009                          | .049 | .057                       | .053 | .063                                | .054 | .040                        | .054 | .046                            | .060 |
| Mentions                 | -.055              | .037 | -.052                         | .037 | -.066*                     | .038 | -.064*                              | .038 | -.061                       | .037 | -.084**                         | .039 |
| Hashtags                 | .026               | .042 | .024                          | .041 | .030                       | .043 | .031                                | .043 | .031                        | .042 | -.019                           | .040 |
| Nonword frequency        | .895***            | .199 | .850***                       | .197 | 1.049***                   | .229 | .981***                             | .206 | .934***                     | .199 | 1.005***                        | .211 |
| Informal words           | -.017***           | .005 | -.015***                      | .004 | -.020***                   | .005 | -.023***                            | .006 | -.020***                    | .005 | -.027***                        | .006 |
| Source                   | .170**             | .074 | .175**                        | .073 | .160**                     | .077 | .162**                              | .077 | .163**                      | .077 | .106                            | .078 |
| Year of tweet            | .062*              | .034 | .058*                         | .033 | .076**                     | .036 | .077**                              | .036 | .077**                      | .036 | .082**                          | .038 |
| Observations             | 163,905            |      | 163,905                       |      | 163,905                    |      | 163,905                             |      | 163,905                     |      | 56,697                          |      |
| R <sup>2</sup>           | .153               |      | .169                          |      | .125                       |      | .123                                |      | .127                        |      | .114                            |      |

\*Significant at 10% level.

\*\*Significant at 5% level.

\*\*\*Significant at 1% level.

Notes: DV = dependent variable; IV = independent variable.

- c. Authors' Conclusions: These results support for the negative relationship between emotionality and brand status and for the potential importance of these variables as fundamental differentiators among brands.

### Study 1b

- a. Answers to RQs and Hypotheses: H1 got additional supported by the visual data; The image emotionality relationship with brand status appears to be especially strong when the variables of text and image emotionality are jointly considered.
- b. Include Key Figures/Tables

**Table 3.** Joint Effects of Image and Text Emotionality on Median Price (Study 1b).

| DV = Median Price        | Emotionality Text IVs |      |                               |      |                            |      |                                     |      |                             |      |                                 |      |
|--------------------------|-----------------------|------|-------------------------------|------|----------------------------|------|-------------------------------------|------|-----------------------------|------|---------------------------------|------|
|                          | Exclamation Points    |      | Normalized Exclamation Points |      | Presence of Capitalization |      | Whissell's Activation Subdictionary |      | LIWC's Affect Subdictionary |      | Evaluative Lexicon Emotionality |      |
|                          | B                     | SE   | B                             | SE   | B                          | SE   | B                                   | SE   | B                           | SE   | B                               | SE   |
| Predictors               |                       |      |                               |      |                            |      |                                     |      |                             |      |                                 |      |
| Emotionality text IV     | -.136*                | .080 | -.155**                       | .066 | .024                       | .049 | -.029                               | .018 | -.062*                      | .032 | -.065*                          | .038 |
| Emotionality image IV    | -.100***              | .021 | -.097***                      | .021 | -.095***                   | .022 | -.094***                            | .022 | -.097***                    | .021 | -.111***                        | .023 |
| Text x Image interaction | -.043**               | .020 | -.036*                        | .018 | -.010                      | .010 | .002                                | .008 | -.021**                     | .010 | -.005                           | .010 |
| Control Variables        |                       |      |                               |      |                            |      |                                     |      |                             |      |                                 |      |
| Word count               | .020***               | .006 | .020***                       | .006 | .018***                    | .007 | .019***                             | .006 | .019***                     | .006 | .011                            | .008 |
| URL                      | -.208***              | .071 | -.206***                      | .071 | -.202***                   | .070 | -.197***                            | .071 | -.204***                    | .071 | -.274***                        | .083 |
| Mentions                 | -.007                 | .049 | -.005                         | .049 | -.009                      | .051 | -.011                               | .051 | -.011                       | .051 | -.016                           | .054 |
| Hashtags                 | .045                  | .046 | .045                          | .046 | .047                       | .048 | .046                                | .047 | .047                        | .046 | .000                            | .050 |
| Nonword frequency        | .648**                | .275 | .634**                        | .273 | .653**                     | .308 | .703**                              | .280 | .664**                      | .274 | .676**                          | .288 |
| Informal words           | -.020***              | .007 | -.019***                      | .007 | -.024***                   | .007 | -.024***                            | .008 | -.022***                    | .008 | -.025***                        | .009 |
| Source                   | .208**                | .094 | .213**                        | .094 | .203**                     | .095 | .204**                              | .095 | .201**                      | .095 | .153                            | .112 |
| Year of tweet            | .012                  | .042 | .012                          | .042 | .022                       | .042 | .021                                | .042 | .020                        | .042 | .059                            | .045 |
| Observations             | 36,967                |      | 36,967                        |      | 36,967                     |      | 36,967                              |      | 36,967                      |      | 11,000                          |      |
| R <sup>2</sup>           | .129                  |      | .134                          |      | .116                       |      | .116                                |      | .118                        |      | .102                            |      |

\*Significant at 10% level.

\*\*Significant at 5% level.

\*\*\*Significant at 1% level.

Notes: DV = dependent variable; IV = independent variable.

- c. Authors' Conclusions: Heightened emotionality in both brand texts and images might accelerate the negative inferences of brand status generated from either source alone.

### Study 1c

- a. Answers to RQs and Hypotheses: H1 was further supported in cross-cultural context.

- b. Include Key Figures/Tables (None)
- c. Authors' Conclusions: the negative emotion–status relationship exists cross-culturally, but that it may be stronger in some cultural contexts. For similar results with an alternative measure of brand status

## **Study 2**

- d. Answers to RQs and Hypotheses:
  - i. H1 was supported: Lower brand emotionality led to higher perceptions of brand status.
  - ii. H4 was supported: The effect of emotionality on brand status was moderated by status context. The effect was significant in moderate- and high-status contexts, but not in low-status contexts.
  - iii. H2b was supported conditionally: High-status reference group associations mediated the relationship between emotionality and brand status only in moderate- and high-status contexts.
- e. Include Key Figures/Tables

**Table 4.** Summary of Results for Study 2.

| DVs              | Low-Status Context                    |                                        | Moderate-Status Context               |                                        | High-Status Context                   |                                        |
|------------------|---------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
|                  | M <sub>low emotion</sub><br>(N = 102) | M <sub>high emotion</sub><br>(N = 107) | M <sub>low emotion</sub><br>(N = 103) | M <sub>high emotion</sub><br>(N = 108) | M <sub>low emotion</sub><br>(N = 105) | M <sub>high emotion</sub><br>(N = 104) |
| Brand status     | 3.93<br>(1.27)                        | 4.11<br>(1.52)                         | 5.35<br>(.97)                         | 4.98<br>(1.21)                         | 5.92<br>(.82)                         | 5.40<br>(1.20)                         |
| Contrast p-value | p = .459                              |                                        | p = .013                              |                                        | p < .001                              |                                        |
| Reference groups | 2.75<br>(1.41)                        | 2.89<br>(1.79)                         | 4.49<br>(1.54)                        | 4.10<br>(1.46)                         | 5.44<br>(1.10)                        | 4.92<br>(1.36)                         |
| Contrast p-value | p = .682                              |                                        | p = .029                              |                                        | p = .002                              |                                        |

Notes: DV = dependent variable. N = 629, 307 women, M<sub>age</sub> = 37 years, MTurk. One participant from the original sample of N = 630 opted out of the survey.

- f. Authors' Conclusions: (1) Brand emotionality does not uniformly affect brand status perceptions across contexts. (2) Status context functions as a critical boundary condition.

## **Study 3**

- a. Answers to RQs and Hypotheses:
  - i. H1 was supported: Lower brand emotionality led to higher perceptions of brand status.
  - ii. H2a was supported: Lower brand emotionality increased alignment with high-status communication norms.
  - iii. H2b was supported: Lower brand emotionality increased high-status reference group associations.
  - iv. H3 was supported: Norm alignment and reference group associations mediated the relationship between emotionality and brand status.
- b. Include Key Figures/Tables

**Table 5.** Summary of Results for Study 3.

| DVs              | Emotionality                  |                                    |                                | p-Values                 |                           |
|------------------|-------------------------------|------------------------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------|---------------------------|
|                  | M <sub>low</sub><br>(N = 142) | M <sub>moderate</sub><br>(N = 138) | M <sub>high</sub><br>(N = 145) | Low/Moderate<br>Contrast | Moderate/High<br>Contrast |
| Brand status     | 5.00<br>(1.27)                | 4.50<br>(1.49)                     | 4.03<br>(1.69)                 | .005                     | .008                      |
| Norm alignment   | 5.22<br>(1.40)                | 4.63<br>(1.51)                     | 3.86<br>(1.87)                 | .002                     | <.001                     |
| Reference groups | 4.95<br>(1.43)                | 4.40<br>(1.60)                     | 3.74<br>(1.78)                 | .005                     | .001                      |

Notes: DV = dependent variable. N = 425, 206 women, M<sub>age</sub> = 41 years, MTurk.

- c. Authors' Conclusions: Lower brand emotionality increases perceived brand status through alignment with high-status norms and reference group associations.

## Study 4

- a. Answers to RQs and Hypotheses:

- H1 was partially supported: Lower brand emotionality increased perceived brand status for non-hedonic products, but not for hedonic products.
- H5 was supported: Product type moderated the effect of emotionality on brand status; the negative effect of emotionality was attenuated for hedonic products.
- H3 was supported: The emotionality  $\times$  product type interaction effect on brand status was fully mediated by norm alignment and high-status reference group associations.

- b. Include Key Figures/Tables

**Table 5.** Summary of Results for Study 3.

| DVs              | Emotionality                  |                                    |                                | p-Values                 |                           |
|------------------|-------------------------------|------------------------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------|---------------------------|
|                  | M <sub>low</sub><br>(N = 142) | M <sub>moderate</sub><br>(N = 138) | M <sub>high</sub><br>(N = 145) | Low/Moderate<br>Contrast | Moderate/High<br>Contrast |
| Brand status     | 5.00<br>(1.27)                | 4.50<br>(1.49)                     | 4.03<br>(1.69)                 | .005                     | .008                      |
| Norm alignment   | 5.22<br>(1.40)                | 4.63<br>(1.51)                     | 3.86<br>(1.87)                 | .002                     | <.001                     |
| Reference groups | 4.95<br>(1.43)                | 4.40<br>(1.60)                     | 3.74<br>(1.78)                 | .005                     | .001                      |

Notes: DV = dependent variable. N = 425, 206 women, M<sub>age</sub> = 41 years, MTurk.

- c. Authors' Conclusions: Brand emotionality harms status perceptions primarily for non-hedonic products; for hedonic products, emotional expression is more normatively appropriate and thus less damaging to perceived brand status.

## 4. Discussion

- a. Implications

- Brand emotionality on social media can **backfire for status signaling**: lower emotionality aligns with high-status communication norms and increases perceived brand status.
- The findings challenge the common managerial belief that **more emotional brand communication is always beneficial**, especially for status-oriented brands.
- Brands can strategically use **restrained emotional expression** to evoke high-status reference groups and elevate brand status perceptions

- b. Limitations

- a. Emotionality was operationalized mainly through **textual and visual cues** (e.g., punctuation, facial expressions), which may not capture all forms of emotional expression.
  - b. Most experimental studies relied on **MTurk samples**, which may limit generalizability.
  - c. The research focuses on **positive-valence emotionality**; negative emotions were rare in the field data and not deeply examined.
- c. Future Directions
  - a. Future research could examine **other forms of emotional expression** (e.g., audio, video, emojis, storytelling).
  - b. More work is needed to explore **cultural differences** in the emotionality–status relationship.
  - c. Researchers could study how emotionality interacts with **other brand dimensions** (e.g., warmth, competence, authenticity) over time.



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**Response Letter (~600 words)**

**Assessment of the Study**

The use of canonical theory on social distinction aligns well with the research questions proposed in this study. This was my first exposure to this theoretical framework, which effectively builds a bridge between social class distinctions and patterns of emotional expression. In particular, the theory provides a compelling explanation for why emotional restraint may function as a signal of higher social status, especially in Western societies. This perspective is also highly relevant to my own research interests in consumers' emotions and advertising, as it shifts attention from emotional expression as a purely persuasive or engagement-oriented tool to emotional expression as a symbolic and status-laden signal.

The article synthesizes prior literature to argue that a lack of emotional expression distinguishes higher from lower social classes in Western cultural contexts, and it empirically demonstrates that reduced emotionality is associated with higher perceived brand status. One important question that arises from this argument concerns its cultural generalizability. Specifically, does this phenomenon hold true worldwide, or is it culture- or country-dependent? Emotional expressiveness is valued differently across cultures, and in some non-Western or collectivistic societies, emotional restraint may not necessarily signal higher status. This raises the possibility of conducting similar studies across different countries or cultural backgrounds to further explore the boundary conditions of this theory. From my perspective, this line of inquiry would be both theoretically meaningful and practically important, especially for global brands operating across diverse cultural markets.

Methodologically, the most interesting and innovative aspect of this study is its integration of cultural and sociolinguistic understandings of emotional expression. Rather than treating emotionality as a purely psychological construct, the author operationalizes it through concrete linguistic and visual cues commonly found in social media content, such as punctuation, word choice, and facial expressions in images. I found the combination of linguistic and visual manipulations particularly compelling, as it reflects how brands communicate emotionality in real-world digital environments. This multimodal approach strengthens the ecological validity of the experiments and demonstrates a thoughtful application of theory to contemporary advertising contexts.

**Weaknesses of the Study**

Despite its strengths, the study also has several limitations. First, although emotionality is manipulated through multiple channels, these manipulations remain relatively controlled and simplified. Real-world brand communication on social media often involves more complex emotional dynamics, including emojis, videos, music, and interactive engagement with users. As a result, the operationalization of emotionality, while methodologically clean, may not fully capture the richness of emotional expression in actual brand communication.

Second, the study relies primarily on MTurk samples from North America. While this is appropriate for theory testing, it may limit the generalizability of the findings, particularly given that the theoretical argument is closely tied to Western norms of status and emotional restraint.

This reinforces the need for cross-cultural replication and comparative research to determine whether the same relationship between emotionality status holds in other sociocultural contexts.

### **Other Notes and Reflections**

In the literature review, the author cites many relevant studies examining the impact of emotionality on content virality. However, many of these studies appear to address very similar research questions (i.e., the positive effects of emotionality on content sharing) while differing mainly in their measurements, methods, or contextual settings. This raises an important methodological reflection for my own research. Given that purely innovative and entirely original research questions are often difficult to develop, this article illustrates that meaningful contributions can still be made by reframing existing questions through a new theoretical lens or by shifting the outcome of interest. Instead of focusing on virality or engagement, this study examines status inferences, thereby generating novel insights from a familiar research domain.

Overall, this paper provides a strong example of how theory-driven experimental design can challenge dominant assumptions in advertising research and open new avenues for studying emotional expression beyond its immediate persuasive effects.